FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Sometimes justice gets lost in the thicket of the law and the legal process. Sometimes common sense is needed. Consider for a moment where the world champion women wrestlers fighting for justice come from. The struggles they have gone through to reach where they have. They all come from humble backgrounds and from a highly conservative environment. People notice women in sports when they reach the podium, after which there's a shower of confetti, awards and celeb endorsements. No one sees the lonely trek, often from the most inimical of places, the battle with inner and outer demons, with material want and historical disadvantage. Wrestling, the most macho of sports, was an all-male affair conducted in the mud pits of deeply patriarchal Haryana, a place where their mothers and grandmothers would have spent life behind a *ghoonghat*.

Look at their courage to put their careers at risk and to come out openly to protest something as personal as sexual harassment. It could possibly imperil their lives even after their sporting life is over. They occupied Delhi's protest square for five months, sleeping on dhurries, fobbing off threat and ridicule and innuendo, breaking down police barriers and, on occasion, themselves breaking down, going against the establishment with just their grit as ammunition, getting pinned to the ground with the Indian flag next to them and never giving up. In that battle, they accomplished feats perhaps greater than their moments of sporting glory. They became the face and voice of Indian women. A defiant symbol of female Indian athletes and their will to overcome. And they brought their long, lonely fight to the centre-stage of national discourse by sheer moral force.



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As if that was not bravery enough, look at the person they have taken on. The don of the wrestling world, Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, who ran the Wrestling Federation of India for 12 years. The very person on whom their career and livelihoods depended. They are now bearding the lion in his den. Through an aggregate of formal allegations, anecdotal evidence and corroborative statements, he stands accused of many repeat acts of sexual harassment—suggesting a pattern of predation from a position of unquestioned power. In 14 specific incidents, related by seven complainants, Singh is said to have molested them or sought sexual favours during sporting events, medal ceremonies or forced private audiences. He allegedly threatened them with dire consequences if they didn't oblige. Contrary to claims of these being "old incidents"—not that it should matter—eight happened in the last five years, five in 2022.

For months, the system was unresponsive and hostile to the women. It imputed motives, impugning their protest as political and caste-driven. Singh brazened it out with the sort of impunity that comes only when you're confident of owning the system. The Delhi Police's methodical tardiness was a satellite reflection of that power. Its inquiry proceeded at a snail's pace despite a prod from the Supreme Court—and then came a bizarre demand for proof. The law recognises that women do not move around with permanent CCTV cameras on their person to record every lewd gesture that comes their way, every transgression of their space via word or deed, every moment of humiliation. That's why it accepts the victim's testimony in sexual crimes. Here, we have a small orchestra of mutually reinforcing voices. All of them sporting figures with much to lose—international careers, and potential Olympic medals.

Singh's power flows not only from his helmsmanship of the WFI but from a regular Indian curse, of politicians heading over half our sports federations. Singh, too, is a BJP MP from Kaiserganj. A bahubali-style neta typical of Uttar Pradesh, with a past of gangland violence and local muscle. Furthermore, he runs a chain of 54 education institutions along a 100-km stretch from Ayodhya to Shravasti. In this mini-kingdom in Awadh, his sprawling rural homestead befits a small-time raja whose aura is both modern and ancient: a fleet of SUVs and a Robinson R-66 turbine helicopter parked in the backyard, a stable of horses and cattle-shed right across. His clout took him to Parliament six times. His family is well entrenched in local politics. No wonder, despite the infamy it has brought the BJP by association, the government has been tiptoeing lightly. Besides his own seat, Singh controls 4-5 Lok Sabha seats in central UP. And because he's from the dominant Thakur/Rajput caste, the potential electoral damage could go well beyond.

Still, things finally turned this month, albeit partially and after an unconscionable gap. The protesting athletes had started gathering too much amplitude and public sympathy: they evidently had the force of truth behind them. Why would seven different women imperil top sporting careers they had fought so hard to build if there was no genuine yearning for justice behind it? That one of its local strongmen in UP politics was constantly under a negative public gaze was a matter of acute discomfort for the BJP. Moreover, the protesters were largely Jats, and they were beginning to rally together—the wrestlers and farmers' unions were making common cause. The BJP had already burnt its fingers with Jat farmer-led protests in 2021-22. Spread across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, Delhi and western UP, Jats swing results in 54 Lok Sabha constituencies and 211 assembly segments. The spectre of another contagion of dissent and a Jat away-swing so close to crucial elections was worrying. Election was announced for the WFI chief's post. Union sports minister Anurag Thakur promised that no Singh proxy would be allowed to contest. And now, there's a chargesheet, as promised. But the BJP might need to mollify the don who is a saffron stormtrooper from the days of the Babri demolition. Singh possibly has enough gunpowder to blast through on his own. Or cut a deal with old pals in the Samajwadi Party. For an Opposition politician handed low-hanging fruit, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has been curiously silent on the protests.

The Modi government has done much to bring dignity to the lives of women. It even launched the Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao scheme in 2015. Ironically, one of the protesting women wrestlers was made its brand ambassador in 2016. It is, therefore, surprising that the government has not acted with greater urgency.

All this complex politics is tangential to the core issue, which is quite simple and not subject to fair-weather conditions. This is the security Indian women feel in public spaces, an inalienable right not meant to be surrendered to the whims of maladjusted males. Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee, Deputy Editor Suhani Singh and the INDIA TODAY team bring you all aspects of this bruising combat. Most of all, the voices of the women wrestlers. Their experiential reality, the distress and terror of having to fob off men with absolute control of their lives, forms a cruelly ironic backdrop to the story of women who defied patriarchy to become athletes.

They have already won by arriving where they have. Any defeat now would be ours.

(Aroon Purie)